

VLAD'S CHRONICLES



Episode 5
VLAD AND THE QUEEN
by T.T.Rider

Disclaimer

The novels of Vlad's Chronicles are an exclusive comedic journey tailored specifically for the delightful members of the

[Hopperverse](#)

If you stumbled upon these adventures by accident, be warned: Vlad's galaxy-hopping escapades, gummy-fueled rulers, and questionable fashion sense may seem more perplexing than trying to explain interstellar BBQ etiquette to aliens.

Non-club members risk bouts of laughter-induced confusion, mild existential crises, or sudden cravings for Ukrainian gorilka.

Read responsibly, and remember—without [Coffee with Christopher](#) context, Vlad's misadventures make about as much sense as a fanny pack in space.

This novel is a wild ride of fiction!

Any names you stumble across, especially those that sound like they belong to [Hopperverse](#) members or die-hard [Coffee with Christopher](#) fans, as well as the characters, places, and shenanigans within, are purely figments of the author's imagination—trust me, it's a pretty bizarre place!

If you happen to see any resemblance to actual events or real people (photos included!), it's entirely by accident—not a conspiracy! Seriously, just dive into this chaotic world, have a blast, and keep in mind that the author is just here to sprinkle a little ridiculous fun into our otherwise serious lives.

Enjoy the laugh riot!

Vlad's Chronicles

by T.T.Rider

Episode 5

Vlad
and
The Queen

Previously in Vlad's Chronicles...

Vlad, war hero, romantic fool, and unapologetic fanny pack fashion icon, still scours the galaxy for Nikki, his elusive Vegas flame. His misadventures have already landed him on a toe-sacrificing island under Big G-Nubz, at the BBQ empire of Troy King, and in the middle of Christopher's impulsive marriage to an actual Siren. Most recently, Vlad crashed partied through New Vegas in Space, where blindfold games, magic gummies, and the ever-mischievous Lynn led to unexpected weddings and regrettable encounters with the Asgoikyos. Nikki remains out of reach, but Vlad's legend and his list of awkward escapades just keep growing.

In an instant, the void of hyperspace vanished, revealing a stunning panorama of the infinite cosmos, stars scattered across it like diamonds flung across black velvet. Over the years, Vlad, our war hero and the protector of the G-Nubz colony, had witnessed this spectacle hundreds of times. Yet each occasion, when that bizarre and perplexing realm known simply as Hyperspace gave way to the boundless night of open space, his features lit up with fresh wonder at the transformation.

Once again, Vlad found himself journeying onward. But unlike his past adventures, spent drifting without purpose in a hopeless pursuit of Nikki, the lingering echo of his affection, this time, Vlad was on a mission.

Spread out before Vlad was a stunning blue planet, its surface almost entirely swallowed by ocean, except for an archipelago of half a dozen sizable islands and countless smaller ones scattered among them, like confetti tossed across a pond.

He fished a scrap of paper from his pocket, which looked suspiciously similar to the wrapper they used for Boomzick burgers at King's B.B.Q. Unfolding it, he squinted at the rough map of the archipelago scrawled there, hunting for the right island. For all the advanced technology in existence, across every known universe, Vlad still had a habit of jotting down crucial details on whatever piece of paper he found handy, his handwriting an indecipherable jumble of Ukrainian, English, and other languages. No one but Vlad could hope to read it, and even he struggled sometimes, especially if a measurable amount of Dunkelbranntstoffer had been involved.

He rotated the map this way and that, then flipped it upside down a couple of times before finally syncing it up with the view of the planet on his monitor. After that, it was simple enough; Vlad keyed the chosen location into the nav computer and set his ship on course for descent.

As Vlad's scout ship dipped nearer to the planet's surface, his target started to take form. The island below looked like a skewed dinosaur caught mid-belly flop into the sea. It stretched no more than sixty miles from end to end, and at its broadest, right around where the dinosaur's errr... backside would be, it was barely twenty miles across. A low chain of hills ran through the middle, dividing the upper part of the island from the lower, while a chunkier set of mountains jutted up at the northernmost tip.

Vlad gave his scribbled map one last glance, then steered for the valley just north of those hills.

After a textbook landing, no alarms, no emergencies, Vlad's first order of business was to tell the ship to toss the crate out of the cargo bay.

This crate stretched nearly twelve feet long and weighed enough to make the ship groan every time Vlad changed the course, or even cleared his throat too loudly. It was like trying to hide a yak in a broom closet, but it fit, somehow. As for what was inside? Vlad hadn't the faintest clue, and frankly, preferred to keep it that way.

Once the crate had been hauled out and dumped next to the ship, Vlad grunted in approval, dug into his pocket, fished out a fistful of brightly coloured gummies, and popped them into his mouth.

Just a few weeks back, he'd come down with a sharp pain in his left big toe. He'd made a quick trip to see the village shaman, who had once been a medical doctor on Earth but now managed to blend both professions. During that visit, Vlad learned he was dealing with arthritis. Lynn recommended chopping the toe off, and even brought her trusted hatchet, but Big G-Nubz offered a way out that was easier, far nicer, and, honestly, a lot more enjoyable: he just handed over some of his magical, colorful remedies to Vlad.

The gummies did the trick, inspiring Vlad to proclaim at the following communal dinner that he and G-Nubz were officially 'Brothers in Gummies.'

Someone in the crowd, sensibly keeping their identity under wraps, called out, "Or is it Brothers in Gums?" The joke set off a round of laughter among everyone present, while Vlad and G-Nubz responded with perfectly matched scowls.

From that night on, Vlad made sure to always have a stash of those magical cures in his pocket.

With the physical pain problem sorted, Vlad was preparing to tackle another, far more agonising issue: his wardrobe.

What Vlad faced was essentially a diplomatic assignment. He understood he needed to dress the part, as his explicit orders demanded, but strict compliance had never been his strong suit. Muttering in his native Ukrainian under his breath, Vlad found a middle ground: he would stick with his reliable shirt and pants, along with his signature fanny pack decked out in American flag colours. However, as a gesture to appease those who'd sent him, he strapped an ornate ceremonial sword to his left side. The handle was

crafted from polished ebony, set with gold filigree and small gemstones that glimmered when they caught the light. The scabbard itself bore intricate engravings and a subtle sheen of mother-of-pearl inlay. For this particular mission, albeit grudgingly, Vlad chose to leave his rifle behind but kept his dependable sidearm close at hand.

Giving himself a final glance in the old, cracked mirror, he muttered once more, "That'll do. If they are not happy, they can find someone else. I'm not putting on that ridiculous monkey suit they handed me."

Defiant to the last, Vlad stepped off the ship and began making his way up the hills, following the well-trodden path ahead.

As Vlad neared the top of the hill, he caught sight of a woman sitting quietly with her easel, brush poised gracefully in her hand, looking like she'd stepped out of a Jane Austen novel.

When Vlad drew nearer, the woman turned to face him, offering that same warm, welcoming smile and speaking in tones reminiscent of the 'good old days': "Good day to you, sir. Welcome to our domain."

Vlad, taken aback by this greeting and mindful of his diplomatic mission, did his best to respond in kind. "And good day to you as well. I appreciate your gra.. gre.. gracious welcome. My name is Vlad."

"Delighted to make your acquaintance, Sir Vlad," she responded with enthusiasm.

"Err.. about 'sir'... I'm not really a knight. Just Vlad," he replied sheepishly.

"Nonsense. It's plain as day you're a warrior. And that splendid sword at your side marks you as a knight indeed! Modesty does not become you, Sir Vlad. I can recognise true worth when I see it; it's my duty after all."

Each word seemed only to heighten Vlad's astonishment. He felt as though something escaped him entirely. Summoning his most courteous tone, he asked, "Sorry, but what is your name?"

"My name?" she echoed back, momentarily surprised that the newcomer didn't recognise her. Amusement quickly replaced surprise as a playful sparkle lit up her eyes. "You may call me Joanna. By the way, that charming little spaceship of yours, I do hope you won't mind if it finds its way onto my canvas?"

“Oh, yes, no problem,” Vlad replied, stepping closer for a better look at the painting. “It’s beautiful work, you’re really talented! Is painting just a hobby, or do you make money from it?”

“Oh, merely a pastime,” Joanna answered lightly. “Luckily for me, my career allows me plenty of opportunities to indulge.”

Before Vlad could pose another question, their conversation was cut short by a new sound: someone approaching from the opposite side of the hill. Though Vlad couldn’t see who it was just yet, he could clearly hear the singing voice climbing upwards:

“But I would walk five hundred miles,
And I would walk five hundred more,
Just to be the man who walked a thousand miles
To fall down at your door.”

In the next moment, the towering figure appeared at the top of the hill. The man looked like a cross between a retired nightclub bouncer and a college professor who had just discovered the joy of fancy wine. He stood an easy six foot six, with the kind of presence that suggested he could either deliver a lecture on product management or argue passionately about the correct way to butter toast. His casual outfit, a collared sweater stretched across broad shoulders, paired with shoes that had clearly “seen some things”, gave him the aura of someone who might offer you life advice while carrying a suspiciously crinkled shopping bag. His face, equal parts stern and mischievous, seemed permanently prepared to either break into song or tell you exactly why your favorite TV show went downhill after just 14 episodes.

Vlad eyed the newcomer with suspicion, leaning discreetly toward Jo and murmuring, "Joanna, who the hell is this man?"

The newcomer's brow furrowed in dignified disapproval as he replied, his tone grave, "The correct form of address is 'Your Majesty'."

Vlad stared, incredulous. "Majesty? What are you talking about?"

With a delicate laugh and a glint of wit in her eyes, Joanna interjected, "Nick, do compose yourself. Sir Vlad is gracing our humble realm for the first occasion. He is yet unversed in our customs."

Still utterly perplexed, Vlad persisted, "What realm? What customs?"

Nick advanced with stately poise, declaring solemnly, "Sir Vlad, permit me to present Her Majesty Joanna the First, by the Grace of God of the United Kingdom of Great Britain and her other Realms and Territories, Queen, Head of the Commonwealth, Defender of the Faith."

Vlad's eyes widened further. "You're a queen? Truly?"

"I am afraid so," Joanna responded with a mischievous smile that danced in her eyes. "And allow me to introduce The Right Honourable Sir Nick Thomas, Member of Parliament and Prime Minister of the United Kingdom of Great Britain." She leaned closer to Vlad and confided softly, "We graciously bid farewell to Ireland and have since omitted Northern Ireland from the title." Straightening up with her characteristic composure, she continued, "Incidentally, Nick is nearly my devoted husband, for over 29 years

now. If you're feeling adventurous, you might refer to him as the Prince Consort, though I warn you, he scarcely tolerates the designation."

Vlad, a hardened warrior who would dive headlong into a den of dragons simply to retrieve a lost hat or debate philosophy with a troll until sunrise, had never been at a loss for words. Yet here he stood: blinking furiously and thoroughly bewildered. In all his adventures, this was quite possibly the first time he had found himself so entirely out of his depth.

Joanna let out a melodic laugh and declared, "Do compose yourself, I'm only having you on." She then addressed both men with a playful glint in her eye, "Come now, gentlemen, let's dispense with all this ceremony and simply use our Christian names."

Nick advanced with dignified grace and extended his hand. "It is a pleasure to make your acquaintance, Vlad. We have heard many good things in your favour. You are hailed as the saviour of our people, and for that, we remain ever indebted to you. Welcome to the British Empire."

Vlad grasped Nick's hand firmly and replied, "Nice to meet you, too, Nick. When you say 'British Empire', do you mean there's some sort of 'New British Empire'?"

At this suggestion, Nick looked positively scandalised. "Good heavens, no! There is but one British Empire, I assure you. And now it extends across countless universes. Alas, we've no means of contacting Earth anymore, so for the sake of continuity, we've declared this splendid island the new capital of the Great British Empire."

Joanna continued in her composed tone, "You see, when fate cast us ashore here, everyone rather fell back into old habits. The Scots, led by Tracey, promptly trekked northwards,"

"—and resumed distilling whisky within weeks," Nick interjected.

Joanna pressed on, unruffled. "We English remained hereabouts. Three Welsh families wandered off and started their own settlement. Naturally, they called it Wailes."

Vlad turned his gaze to the island lying to the west. "And what about that one?"

Nick nodded. "Ah, yes. Ireland. As Her Majesty mentioned—"

At Joanna's pointed glance, he swiftly corrected himself, "As Jo said, we allowed the Irish their independence."

Vlad pointed towards a larger island farther off. "And who lives over there?"

"Americans," Joanna replied with a wry half-smile. "Energetic folk, thoroughly industrious."

Nick chimed in with a hint of amused resignation, "Though they do insist on electing their own leaders, a most singular custom."

Joanna added lightly, "Some quite admirable specimens among them. And others best left unmentioned."

They strolled leisurely up toward the crest of the hill.

"And what about Canada? Does it still exist?" Vlad inquired.

Nick straightened a little, as if affronted by any suggestion otherwise. "Most certainly, yes. The Americans made several attempts to claim her, but our Governor General, Krista, with

sterling legal support from Dan, rebuffed every advance. Thus, Canada remains proudly within the Empire, as is only proper.”

Another question sprang to Vlad’s mind; he was still marvelling at this whole arrangement. “Do you have Australia as well?”

Joanna laughed once more. “Indeed, we do!”

Vlad grinned mischievously. “And do you still send your troublemakers there?”

Nick chuckled heartily. “No, not anymore. There are already two troublemakers living there, Jason and Dan. If we sent Richard and Krzysztof as well, it would be more than Australia could handle.”

Vlad joined in their laughter before gesturing towards the east.

“And over there?”

“French,” Nick replied crisply.

Joanna added drily, “We’re not entirely over it yet.”

Nick continued with mock solemnity, “Yes, centuries of rivalry reached its glorious conclusion when we put them properly in their place at Trafalgar!” He extended his arm dramatically toward a southern settlement where a tall column stood crowned by a lone figure.

Vlad regarded Nick with evident puzzlement until Joanna explained kindly, “Nick fashioned a perfect replica of Trafalgar Square, including its iconic monument, but in miniature.”

The group continued their descent toward the hovercraft, which was idling at the foot of the hill. After a brief interval, Vlad turned to Nick and asked, “This whole thing with French. If I

remember from school, you were OK after the beginning of the nineteenth century, yes? But looks like old grudges are still hanging around. You plan to keep this going forever?"

Nick gave an elegant shrug. "Certainly not forever, I should think. Perhaps, in two or three hundred years' time, we might begin to relinquish our ancient grievances."

Vlad pondered this before asking quietly, "And what of the French? Do they still feel the same way toward you, Englishmen?"

Nick answered without hesitation, "Oh, most assuredly not! They've long forgotten any such matters. Frankly, they're far too engaged in sipping wine and staging revolutions to trouble themselves with historical quarrels."

Joanna offered a musical laugh. "In truth, they are excellent neighbours. The cuisine and the wine are simply exquisite. We do so enjoy holidaying there."

Before long, they boarded the royal hovercraft and, after a swift twenty-five-minute journey, arrived at the settlement they proudly referred to as London Town.

Upon their arrival in the town, they were met by a jubilant crowd. The streets had been adorned in anticipation of a grand occasion or celebration.

Nick turned gracefully to Vlad. "Dinner shall be served in approximately two hours, at nine o'clock precisely. In the meantime, please do avail yourself of our hospitality at the palace, so that you may rest and prepare for this evening's festivities." He gestured towards a stone residence, noticeably larger than those surrounding it.

Joanna chimed in, "You have chosen a most marvellous day to arrive, Sir Vlad. Today we are hosting a state dinner and festivities that will continue well into the early hours."

Vlad paused abruptly. "Ah. I am forgetting completely. By any chance, is there cargo transport? I left a heavy crate by my ship. I can go quickly and bring it here."

Nick responded with an indulgent smile, "That won't be necessary, I'll arrange for someone to collect it on your behalf. There is no need for you to trouble yourself."

Vlad's brow furrowed in consideration before he replied, "Thank you. And perhaps they will bring my suit also? I hang it, packed outside the ship on the engine nacelle."

Joanna laughed softly, "Not especially fond of formalwear, are you?"

Vlad replied with a non-committal grunt.

"Come along," she continued with a gentle smile, "let me show you to your quarters."

When Vlad entered the ballroom, he was greeted with a dead silence. All conversations stopped.

He stood in the doorway dressed in full regalia. White breeches and stockings, polished black shoes with golden buckles, and a jet-black coat exploding with gold embroidery that shimmered under the chandelier light. A ceremonial sword hung at his side, the ivory handle glinting like it had stepped out of another century.

For a long moment, the only sound was the faint jingle of his dress sword against his thigh. Then a champagne glass somewhere in the corner clinked nervously, as if trying to fill the vacuum of disbelief that his entrance had created.

Vlad scanned the room. He was the sole figure who appeared to have wandered in from the nineteenth century. Everyone else was dressed in understated but fashionable clothing, nothing even close to the lavishness of his own getup. "Lynn!" he muttered quietly. This whole outfit had been Lynn's suggestion. She'd promised him that everyone would be dressed like this, adamant that he wouldn't stick out awkwardly. Now he absolutely did. Thanks a lot, Lynn. Payback was coming, and he had medals for that.

Vlad's chain of thought was abruptly broken by a voice as melodious and poised as a nightingale on a summer evening. Undeniably, it was Joanna. "Sir Vlad, you look positively resplendent!" she exclaimed with an earnest smile, her tone utterly devoid of irony. If anything, she seemed intent on putting him at ease. "I daresay I never anticipated seeing anyone so impeccably attired for the occasion within my court. Thank you ever so much for your effort."

Nick, however, could scarcely contain his amusement. "Yes, I must concede, you do cut quite the dashing figure. Rather grand indeed! But allow me to assure you that our level of technological and societal progress far outstrips the era reflected by your ensemble. By about two centuries, I should think."

"Do behave yourself!" Joanna chastised Nick in a gentle but firm manner. "Sir Vlad has honoured us with his presence. There's no need for teasing."

They proceeded around the ballroom, Joanna and Nick graciously introducing Vlad to their assembled guests. Much to Vlad's pleasant surprise, those he encountered hailed from all walks of life: bakers rubbing shoulders with bankers, mechanics mingling with artists, an assemblage as varied as a patchwork quilt, rather than the stuffy coterie of aristocrats he'd half-expected.

After some time, Vlad could no longer resist the question that had been needling him since his arrival. "Can I ask you something. So, if there are no elections here, how did you decide who would be the King? Or a Queen?"

Nick replied with a mischievous glint in his eye, "Quite straightforward, really: among all the Englishfolk present, only Joanna and I were born in London. Naturally, that made us rulers by default."

"And between the two of you? How did you choose who would take which role?"

Joanna interjected with her trademark composure, "Oh, that was an easy matter. I happened to be born on the north side of the Thames and Nick on the south. Clearly it fell to me to become

Queen,” she said with a playful tilt of her head, “while Nick assumed the post of Prime Minister, and, truth be told, most of the rest of the cabinet. You see, back on Earth Nick’s passion was constructing scale models of aircraft and ships, but now he’s got an entire British Isles to tinker with.” She laughed lightly. “He keeps proposing we construct a railway here, even though we enjoy hovercrafts and all sorts of advanced contraptions!”

Nick broke in enthusiastically, “Britain built the world’s first railway, and it seems only proper we should have one again!”

At that moment, Vlad recalled his true purpose, a diplomatic mission, and decided not to waste any more time. “You may wish to delay your railroad plans for now, Nick. I believe I have something even better for you to build.”

“I’m all ears,” Nick responded eagerly, curiosity lighting up his face.

Vlad began at once. “Your Majesty,” he intoned formally. Joanna frowned ever so slightly at this address, but Vlad pressed on, intent upon his message. “When Plushies seized Miami and everyone in that region, it coincided with the Miami Grand Prix of Formula One. The whole lot was taken: drivers, engineers, pit crews, even team principals. All that talent is now gathered on the New Space Vegas planet. Veronica, the ruler there, sent me here with a proposition: restarting the Formula One championship! Since your planet here is like the original Earth, but in scale,” he gestured broadly around them, “it is logical to start here. So, what would you say to hosting eight out of ten Formula One teams? Just like on old Earth?”

For a heartbeat or two, they simply stared at him, astonishment writ clear across their faces.

Vlad pressed his advantage: "Veronica will keep Ferrari and Toro Rosso, or whatever they're calling themselves these days, and she'll bankroll the entire enterprise. You wouldn't need to spend a single penny."

Finally, Nick found his voice, a rare moment when words had failed him until then, and burst forth excitedly: "Splendid! Absolutely splendid! We shall begin at Woking so McLaren can get off to a flying start; next Silverstone, for both track and factory; Milton Keynes, Grove, Enstone, and Brackley must follow swiftly after." He was waving his hands animatedly now. "And though it may be a tad premature, I insist we include Goodwood House for the Festival of Speed!"

Joanna placed a gentle hand on Nick's sleeve and suggested diplomatically, "Nick dear, we ought also consult our neighbours across the Channel, King Louis the Forty-Eighth himself. I fancy I could persuade him to carve out a little patch dubbed Belgium so we might host Spa-Francorchamps as well."

Vlad blinked in disbelief. "The French still have a king? I thought they gave up monarchy ages ago!"

Joanna laughed merrily. "It is rather an amusing tale! At first, they set up a monarch, as many settlements did, and decided every King would be named Louis with an ascending number for continuity's sake."

Nick picked up where she left off: "But naturally, being French, they couldn't resist revolution for long. Five months later, they

rebelled, not a head lost this time though! Half a year hence, another King was installed since the previous one declined, then another uprising not long after that.” He grinned wryly. “So now they simply nominate a new King or Queen every six months. Louis or Louisa serve their term before declaring Revolution Weekend to celebrate freedom from ‘oppression’, then Monday morning, they crown the next Louis. It suits them.

Their discussion was cut short by the call that dinner was served.

Dinner was surreal. Jeremy Clarkson had supplied the cows, Gordon Ramsay had cooked them, and Jimmy Carr was working through the guest list like a man with a death wish. Even Vlad found himself on the receiving end of Jimmy's barbs, though they were so hilariously cutting he resolved to thrash that cheeky bastard later, once dessert had settled. Of course, that fleeting threat faded from Vlad's mind as he roared with laughter at the next jibe aimed at Nick.

At last, the moment Vlad had eagerly anticipated arrived. Before dinner began, he'd pulled Jimmy aside for a quick word, hinting at the secret gift he was keen to unveil.

Jimmy Carr took centre stage, his grin wicked. "And now," he declared, "the moment we've all been dreading, brought to you by the oversized ape in an outdated suit who apparently needs to compensate for something by wheeling in this ludicrously huge box. Lord knows what horrors lurk inside."

With that, the mysterious container that Vlad had received from Veronica was rolled into position. The top panel had already been removed, yet its contents remained concealed. All at once, magnetic locks disengaged, and every panel clattered to the floor.

Nick drew a sharp breath. "Is this... could it possibly be what I think it is?"

Vlad shrugged and replied, "Don't look at me, I have no damn clue."

Stepping closer, Nick whispered reverently, "I can see the markings! Yes, it's the long gun the French brought to Trafalgar! We

sank their ships and later salvaged these cannons to use as bollards lining London's streets!"

Indeed, inside stood a giant French Navy cannon. Fully loaded. Vlad was 80% sure it could still sink a ship. Why Veronica thought this was a gift, he had no idea.

Nick beamed, "This is simply the finest birthday gift one could hope for!"

Vlad raised his glass high and called out, "Happy Birthday, Nick Thomas!"